

RHETORIC AND ETHICS FINAL PORTFOLIO

by

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Reflection

My definition of rhetoric is hard to pin down, but it lies somewhere within the idea that rhetoric is a tool of understanding, a tool that is influenced by power, agency, capacity, and intent. Rhetoric is the means through which we construct meaning, negotiate shared truth, and attempt to identify with other groups or our own.

Rhetoric and ethics are inseparable forces. Every rhetorical act has ethical implications, especially when there are imbalances in power and agency. Understanding who gets to speak, who is listened to, and the intent behind communication are all questions that allow us to find the ethical implications behind rhetorical acts.

My project seeks to highlight a severe discrepancy in power and agency. By trying to start a discourse with Tina Kotek I am putting into practice the imbalance in power that Hoff-Clausen, Booth, and Goodling (among many others) are concerned with finding. My revised project integrates their theories in a way that allows me to interrogate what rhetoric is, what rhetoric does, and the ethical implications behind who it fails. These revisions were able to more accurately capture the issue I was seeking out in my first paper.

The only questions I'm left with after this course are more existential ones about the future of our government and our institutions. We are living in a time when it feels as though rhetorical acts are accomplishing very little, and I wonder what steps we have to take in order to be heard?

Discussion Board Posts

- I. *Rhetoric is Epistemic?* goes to great lengths to assess, test, interact with, redefine, and synthesize the idea that "Rhetoric is Epistemic." It systematically breaks down the definitions of rhetoric and epistemology, and the subsequent definitions of knowledge, truth, and certainty that are all too often presumed when dealing with rhetoric. The article, in a way that feels aware of its own density, argues for a balance between applicability and rigidity in definition. It goes through many different theories and explores whether they are too rigid, loose, or fallacious to be applicable. The essay, ultimately, is searching for a reform in definition, guiding the exploration of rhetoric and knowledge towards clarity. Something I thought about while reading this piece is how many other fields and scholastic interests suffer from the same rigidity and dogmatism we see here, too tied to previous literature that is epitomized in its field (looking at you, Freud).

The chapter of *The New Jim Crow* starts with a speech by Obama that speaks to the absent Black fathers of America, then begs the question, where might the missing fathers be found? The answer to this question, the chapter posits, is the systemic mass incarceration of Black men, with its roots in the past and its modern instatement through the War on Drugs. The chapter discusses how modern American political rhetoric erases the actor of the justice system and simply poses the "disappearance" of black men as a phenomena with uncertain (but somehow still racist) origins. The cultural zeitgeist that blames Black men for their incarceration is discussed through the metaphor of a single wire in a bird cage, saying that racism is only one single cog in a

system that works to imprison Black men. My question is, will American political rhetoric ever move away from this?

- II. *"I know that my cause is unjust, but winning will be profitable to me, and I'm so skillful that nobody will realise my deceptions: I will employ rhetrickery that appears to be honest."*

This article poses a very sound and pragmatic principle for utilizing and refining our rhetorical skills. The notion of it being "one of our best hopes of saving the world" is a very ambitious one, but still fundamentally sound. The article breaks down the Win, Bargain, and Listening forms of rhetoric, subdividing them into ranges of ethicality. Each subdivision is based on both the skill and intention of the usage, and the author gives us examples that help us grapple with the ethicality and circumstances of each type. The article considers the interplay of these forms in its conclusion. It addresses the ethicality of audience, and how a message, in most cases, must change to some degree to be heard by an audience with unique and specific values. The quote I chose above, to me, is very emblematic of the current state of affairs in America. A question I think deserves to be explored is how all of these methods interact with each other in very interesting ways, every rhetorical technique actually depends a great deal on the rhetorical technique it is in conversation with. The text touches on this utopian idea of every debate using *LR-a*, where both sides are genuinely interested in hearing each other out to pursue the truth of their differences, but sadly we have to consider every malicious, deceiving, and cunning combination of rhetorical techniques that bring us further from a unified understanding of one another. I was also curious on where these

methods intersect History. Also how the way we judge rhetoric as ethical or unethical ultimately depends on our circumstances.

- III. Bitzer argues that rhetoricians have been focusing on rhetoric and discourse without examining the underlying cause of rhetoric, the rhetorical situation. Bitzer uses a list of conditions to state that rhetorical discourse is a response to a rhetorical situation, and cannot exist without the rhetorical situation from which it originates. Next, Bitzer defines what an *exigence* is, and how the "something that has to be done" it represents can be ruled rhetorical if it can be changed, more specifically through discourse to undergo positive modification. He goes to an even further length to describe the other "constituents" of the "complex": the constraints under which response to exigence takes place, and audience. The ideas brought up later in the paper essentially claim that works may appear rhetorical but are simply not rhetorical unless they have a "real" rhetorical situation that justifies a fitting rhetorical response. Vatz's response to Bitzer's theory posits that his construction of meaning and intent is far too narrow, since situations are not objective, and meaning is not always apparent. Vatz takes issue with the idea that the world and its history can be interpreted objectively, and argues that rhetorical situations are not the creators of meaning, rather it is our interpretation. Vatz emphasizes that the application of rhetoric is a choice, not a consequence. Vatz suggests that Bitzer got everything backwards, and that rhetoric is what defines a situation. Salience is a choice! A question I had is how does Bitzer justify that claim that scientific authors do not require an audience, implying that scientific knowledge does not require discourse to be true. Another is as-to-what-the-hell-he-meant when Bitzer refers to

rhetoric as a "mode of altering reality" does that idea not come into conflict with the idea that *reality* is what causes rhetorical situations to arise initially?

- IV. In *The Range of Rhetoric*, some points that clicked for me were the relationships between identification and division. The idea that between two separate people, there can be a oneness in interest--genuine or otherwise-- that can lead to discourse. When two interlocutors have different individual motives, aims, and beliefs but share a common interest, they will begin a dialogue- an undefined, at times antagonistic movement towards a more realized understanding of that shared interest. Identification can be a group, an individual belief, or a larger structural role, all of which bring people into a sphere where discourse can happen. (Sort of.) Warner defines a public as a self-organized audience, comprised of strangers. A public is created through mere attention to an address; this address contains a simultaneous personal and impersonal facet. Essentially, when public speech enters the nebulous "engine for social mutation", it is (required to be) taken up by an audience and is acted upon according to the "temporaility of the public's circulation", the history, intertextuality, and future of a discourse that comprises the public. A public, in this sense, is an evolving, intertextual, social space where discourse enters and is churned about with the history and future of its impact. A counterpublic, then, is a social space that operates outside of the protocols and expectations of the dominant public, with limited circulation among the estranged audience. A question I had reading Warner was considering the idea that "no single text can create a public", which made me think about texts that started a form, genre, or method. For example, the very first website to ever exist, did that on its own create a

public? Does calling rhetoric "concerned with the state of Babel after the fall" imply that our discourses are mostly guesswork towards a mutual understanding?

- V. Jordan's article orbited around the idea of dialog-by-intermediary, specifically, narratives that (usually harmfully) were taken across the Black and White racial divide in America. The piece is concerned with how Black voices have historically never been listened to, and how Black people have historically been objectified. The idea that narratives are something that can be "brought off" better by an intermediary voice outside of a group is an obscene and harmful one. Jordan uses many examples of white intermediaries misinterpreting, misrepresenting, and appropriating black voices and narratives in a self-righteous and flagrantly harmful way. The article concludes with the plea that the voices of Black people should be listened to and understood by White people, instead of co-opted into their own narratives. Ratcliffe's article is difficult to summarize and a bit difficult to parse at times. The idea that Rhetorical Listening consists of the responsibilities and possibilities of interpretative invention (or "making meanings via language via others"). The article aims to distinguish rhetorical listening as distinct from, but interwoven with other rhetorical tropes like reading, writing, and speaking. Ratcliffe is concerned with the intersectionality of listening, with focus on commonality and difference, and how a very wide multitude of factors (like gender, ethnicity, whiteness, and the privileges associated with identities) have at times hindered the ability to rhetorically listen as well as systematically subjugated the trope of listening into a subordinate role to other forms of rhetoric. As rhetorical listeners, we should be "cultivating and negotiating conventions of discourse communities".

Without trying to buy into a binary construction of gender, I was interested in the difference gender has on listening, and how the stereotypical associations of men listening argumentatively and women listening self-critically are systematically enforced. I wonder how we can stop, and catch ourselves listening uninterpretively in the moment?

- VI. Yergeau's article is centered on the idea of Perseveration, and seeks to redefine our understanding and usage of the word. Yergeau argues that our definition should extend beyond the psychiatric pathological definition of an activity that occurs "beyond a desired point", posing the idea that this "point" in question is defined by a structure that is posed against disabled and neurodivergent people. The article argues that stimming, and in a greater sense perseveration, are rhetorical and communicative acts. They are acts that allow disabled and neurodivergent people to negotiate hostile spaces, and it is a tool that Yergeau argues, allow for "writing and multimodally composing, creating scenes and disrupting, crippling, defying, and spiraling." By understanding perseveration under the lens of disability justice, we see that it in some ways is a tool for navigating life. Yergeau goes on to build a critique of universal design, and exemplifies how it de-emphasizes disability, and often misrepresents disability. One example (of many) of this is in a critique of universal design in the workplace, where many office spaces are difficult to navigate or operate in for neurodivergent people, and how many companies employ the principles of universal design in a backhanded way, where yes, it may provide a more comfortable workspace, but it is doing so only for the end of productivity. This point is also made clear in the programs that help hire

and exemplify (usually cis white male) autistic workers, but does so in a way that demeaningly portrays them as workers who never get bored of repetitive tasks, and are math and technology oriented. These points work together to build a more comprehensive understanding of perseverance. This article makes me question how far behind we are legislatively on access issues. What is the distinction between retrofitting as additive versus reimaginative?

- VII. This piece caught me by surprise. I thought I knew where it was headed, and I was planning out my response in my head, it had more to do with the mythologized *Crusty Old White Man* whose english we still invariably depend on for academia. In the first half of the essay, I was more focused on the systematic categorization of Black English. Jordan discusses the lack of recognition that Black English (or any other form) receives in America as White English is the enforced standard of language, then proceeds to question this status through her teaching. Jordan then introduces Willie Jordan, the student in Contemporary Women's Literature who she went on to work with closely in an independent study. After undertaking a method of teaching 'The Art of Black English', we see the framework of Black English pushed into motion, where it collides with the story of Willie Jordan. The essay brings the murder of Willie's brother, Reggie Jordan, to the class, and has them formulate a way to generate a discourse, a call to action, and a response to the situation. The class settles on sending messages in Black English to the Jordan family, the police department, and to the media. The doomed nature of these messages, the lack of response to them, and the lack of action that was spurned from their writing is perhaps distilled in a quote from Willie Jordan: "... I

believe that to a large degree, justice may only exist as rhetoric." A question I had throughout the reading was, how do we incorporate more kinds of English in our education, is merely teaching books like *Their Eyes Were Watching God* enough to understand modes of language? Is there more to the irony behind categorically defining Black English under the framework of White English?

- VIII. At risk of oversimplifying the article, the idea "that location bears on meaning and truth is not the same as saying that location determines meaning" was very central to my understanding of this piece. Alcoff explores the ethicality and validity of speaking for others, and settles in some ways, on location location location. Alcoff constructs a framework of truth, of what "others" actually means, and sets up a two premise structure to view speaking for others under the view of location, and within systems of power that structure society. Alcoff contends that certain approaches either reduce the issue too small, or retreat from the issue altogether, but still advocates for specific uses that do not undermine concepts like political efficacy by limiting 'prohibition' to specific discursive spaces. Alcoff then complicates this understanding by exploring how one cannot truly speak only for oneself, as there is no decisive boundary between the location of the self and the other (discursively). Ultimately, for Alcoff, the method of discursively retreating is one too far from reality, which generalized, and eludes the agency and responsibility of a speaker, and is moreso an attempt to avoid criticism than it is to aid marginalized voices. Alcoff then proposes the idea of 'speaking to (or rather, with)' instead of 'speaking for' where we should constantly strive for dialogue, even when capitalist, imperialist systems are not particularly fond of it. Alcoff then offers a

4 part algorithm: Impetus for speaking (based on location), Interrogate the bearing of our location (no unanalyzed disclaimers!), Speak with accountability, Consider the effects of your speech. Why do discussions of intersectionality in academia tend to end at authors instead of critics (like ourselves)? What can we do to try to apply these principles to more empirically-oriented fields like history, and include more representational voices?

- IX. Emma Camp's piece on self-censorship and ideological conformity on college campuses takes a stance against the modern day lack of diversity in discourse. The issue here, is not one necessarily of free speech, but the cultural zeitgeist of college campuses, and their tendency to reinforce a unified progressive perspective, often causing an ostracization or even an antagonism of the individual who voices their opinion. This cultural shift has brought on the practice of self-censorship for students whose political or personal views may deviate from the socially acceptable, and institutionally reinforced mainline. Camp is moreso advocating for the diversity of viewpoints, not trying to validate or endorse any specific view. This idea is closely tied to the importance of discourse, with many of the articles linked inside of the piece being related to speakers or individuals being blocked from speaking at events, or having their voices taken out of the public sphere. Camp is concerned with the practice of censorship regardless of actor, and argues that even viewpoints that are objectively questionable should be heard, and subsequently questioned. Camp finds the source of this issue to be multifaceted, engrained, and complex. The call is not for individual students alone to change their stance on the matter, but an engagement on every level,

institutional, personal, and societal. I personally feel a little conflicted in some of the small details of the matter, for example, if there were a guest speaker on campus who was overtly spreading a hateful message, would we be given the opportunity to engage in discourse, or would we have to act to stop them from speaking uncontested? Do institutions allow us to genuinely engage in discourse with their views and policies, or do bureaucratic processes detach us from our agency in discourse, leaving us few options to engage?

- X. The npr talk hosted by Ari Shapiro covered a New York Post publication that featured "a man trapped in the path of an oncoming subway train". The talk featured experts, scholars, and commentators to weigh in on the ethics of publishing such a violent image. The first speaker, Folkenfilk, a media correspondent for npr gave a clear account of the event. He discussed how The Post, despite not commenting on the matter, has made its stance clear by running the story day after day, and let the publication speak for them. Folkenfilk weighs in, saying that images of violence are not used without "evoking a greater truth", and argues that this portrayal may provide a small insight into something, but is more prominently a way for The Post to generate attention, and thus revenue. The next speaker, John, was an Army journalist, who had to make the choice about what violence to photograph, and what violence to publish. His perspective brings light to the photograph itself, and how their involvement in the violence should be considered as well. Next, Kelly McBride, an ethics and journalism scholar, who argues that violence should only be portrayed in media with purpose. She argues that this image does not allow the audience to understand, act, or intervene in

any way, and thus is more of a voyeuristic, exploitative use. To offer an alternative to this understanding, Stephen Mayes argues that there is a discussion to be had about the issue, mental health, crime, the value of photographs in building a fuller understanding. Other callers weighed in, often focused on preserving dignity while providing documentation. How should we interact with graphic media on public forums (social media)? Is it ever ethical to release graphic media like security footage to the public (as evidence or otherwise)?

- XI. Hariman & Lucaites's article examines the ethical and epistemological impact of iconic photographs. It uses the 'napalm girl' photo as the fulcrum of its analysis. The article gives a dense breakdown of stranger identification, political identity, shared collaborative consciousness, and issues of performative embodiment and ideological representation in images. They use this image to argue that iconic images can shape public identity, and collective memory, and that once an image gains a level of mass circulation among a public, it can face many different forms of interpretation and or rearticulation. They argue that images aren't simply reflections of public thought, but they play a large role in shaping public thought. This follows through to the examples of reimaginings of this iconic photo, that more overtly articulate the political understandings behind it. The example of the photo of the woman, Kim Phuc, shows how an image can change over time, become a response to itself, and embody a shift from public to private values. The authors also take time to discuss the gendered implications behind images like the ones of Kim, as well as images from the Kent State Massacre, emphasizing how the photos do contain structured, normalized gender roles

in their representations, and that they do both literally reflect the state of ideological gender narratives in the United States. These elements culminate in a rhetorical, ethical reading of the photographs that underscores how the violation of normalcy that is presented in them, is both a cause of, and a reflection of the violation that is tangibly taking place within the photos. It seems interesting how media circulation is so widespread, yet photos that become truly 'iconic' only tend to arise only a few times a decade. Are our understandings of iconic photos limited to westernized art by our identity as Americans?

- XII. Jingnan and Lawrence's piece focuses on the systematic erasure of history and identity from government websites. Whether articles were edited to reflect less inclusive values, or erased entirely, there is clear evidence of erasure brought on by the recent DEI changes brought on from Trump. The alternative rhetoric is clear, while on one end the administration claims to be fighting against a "unlawful, corrosive, and pernicious identity-based spoils system", on the other they are removing parts of history like the Navajo Code Talkers, or literally images of women from government websites. The articles warns of the unchecked, rampant removal of any narrative outside of the imagined white male pre-contact America that is fallaciously trying to be upheld by erasures like these. Jennings-Roche's article discusses the significance of libraries and public works, and the role they play in upholding democratic values. The article discusses how right-wing extremist rhetoric is a thinly veiled neoliberal fascism that seeks to homogenize the American narrative into one that aligns with whiteness and '*rightness*' (irony doesn't travel well through text box). An important point emphasized

in the article is that of book banning/challenging, it is asserted that even recognizing the possibility of banning books is an affront to democracy, and libraries cannot and should not hide behind a facade of neutrality, calling for a unified front of library workers to hold the democratic and scholarly values that exist outside of neoliberal solutionism. Jennings-Roche stresses how deceptive the rhetoric of book banners is, seeking to undermine the value of both libraries and librarians, pretending to have the interests of children at heart, while surreptitiously having the interests of white, right-wing fascism at heart. How can there even be an argument against 'Free People Read Freely'? How did we get to this point as a 'free' country?

- XIII. (This was first time I've heard the term meatspace be used, ever, in any context.) Goodling's interactive piece on digital activism poses the question about digital communication and rhetoric, why do we not consider it activism? The piece opens talking about generational, and cultural divides that lead people to discredit digital activism. Warner's idea of publics and counterpublics is used as a framework to show that digital activism meets the requirement of addressing a public and forming counterpublics, emphasizing the idea that a public forum empowers all users equally by design. The piece connects the power of a public digital media culture with the growing rates of activism, or desire for activism in young people (under 26 lol), and shows how social media can be a source of information as well as a gateway to other forms of activism. This idea bleeds into the next, where it talks about statistics showing that a hybridized, online and *meatspace* activism is one of the most effective forms currently. The pieces discussion on 'slacktivism' argues that the point of "The

revolution will not be televised" no longer applies to many online forums, arguing that online social mobilization is far reaching, and that education is a form of change, if we choose to value tangible change. The piece goes on to discuss how online civil disobedience is labeled terrorism when it is done against a government, and is a misleading label, and is often used to discredit cyberactivism. The piece then identifies some relevant terms to digital activism. The piece wraps up with discussions of journalism, writing, rhetoric, and education, saying that any activism is better than no activism. Is digital activism not more susceptible to silencing and censorship than BoTG activism? Is digital activism at greater risk of spreading misinformation than other forms?

Unrevised Unit Project #1

Ethical Implications of Rhetorical Agency

The focus of my paper will be on trying to apply a framework of rhetorical agency based on the definition and application offered by Hoff-Clausen. By analyzing rhetorical agency among social structures and individuals, I plan to approach the different kinds of rhetorical used based on Booth's "Judging Rhetoric". The use of rhetoric, unfortunately, collides with the restraints of reality, and the agency given to a rhetor is dependent on many factors. I want to explore the larger dynamics at play behind when, how, and to what degree of efficacy rhetoric can be used, with the specific focus on top-down interactions of rhetoric and the ethical implications of their inequality. While the constructions of rhetoric within discourse communities, and the idea of discourse between interlocutors are useful, I want to try to focus on the agency that different actors have when using rhetoric, and how these interactions can be inherently unethical. The premise of my analysis is the agency associated with different rhetorical actors. The example I will use to explore this will be me attempting to contact Governor Tina Kotek.

Different groups in society (I.E. individuals, societies, institutions, governments, etc.) have uneven degrees of rhetorical agency, and this imbalance in dialogue raises ethical concerns about who gets a say in shaping the shared reality that is created through rhetoric. My primary method for exploring this framework will be to attempt to personally open a dialogue with a government institution. When rhetorical interactions happen between individuals, societies, and systems, there are different levels of agency available to the actor, especially contingent on the willingness of the second party to listen or interact. These interactions will be viewed through the

construction of rhetorical agency that Hoff-Clausen offers, and it will coincide with Booth's ideas about rhetorical methods and types. The functional definition I am using is that rhetoric is utilized to create common ground, it opens dialogues between groups or individuals that have unique constructions of reality, and it tries to settle the differences, finding commonality and compromise in the gaps. I want to address the inherent inequalities between these groups, focusing on the idea that the larger, more powerful groups that use rhetoric can impose their construction of "truth" on the smaller groups more easily than in reverse. I also want to address the restraints in agency that rhetors have in when using rhetoric, and how systems of power often lead to individuals and minority groups having a lack of agency, thus disempowering their rhetoric, and placing them in an inherently unethical imbalance of dialogue.

Under Booth's framework, when I send an email to the office of Tina Kotek, I am utilizing listening rhetoric – b: *"Though I am quite sure that my opponent is determined to ignore my case, I will listen to [theirs], hoping to discover some way to engage [them] in genuine dialogue"* (47). While Booth describes this interaction as one that poses the rhetor against "dogmatists who seem to be unshakably committed to an absolutely unquestionable cause" (47), this situation seems more complex. In my message to my Governor, I asked why federal immigration agencies are allowed to operate freely in a state that considers itself a sanctuary state. The response I received was not from Tina Kotek, but rather "Governor Kotek's Constituent Services Team" (Kotek), and rather than genuinely addressing my question, I received a message comprised entirely of boilerplate rhetoric and buzzwords, which never addressed my message. While Booth's points don't accurately capture what this interaction is, Hoff-Clausen has a more practical explanation. Hoff-Clausen posits that there is a dimension beyond willingness that allows dialogue to occur, and that we should look to "the many

contextual factors of influence... to how the speakers and their audiences are positioned [in] ... situational, organization, and societal structures” (Hoff-Clausen, 20). This idea of limitation goes both ways, when Hoff-Clausen says that “agency precedes the agent” (13), here it means that before I ever sent my message, I knew it wouldn’t be genuinely considered by my government (which Booth’s framework does align with). When considering the response I received, however, there are a few questions raised. Does a statement like “Governor Kotek remains focused on making progress on Oregonian’s top priorities and will fight to protect Oregon values no matter what’s happening in D.C.” (Kotek), even count as rhetoric? Which of Booth’s frameworks does this fit into? I can’t find a satisfying answer, as the response is automated, and sought in no way to interact with my rhetoric, the only goal seeming to be a half-assed seeking of complacency. When Kotek’s team says she will “work to ensure our laws, policies and actions remain a deterrent to attacks on our shared values and fundamental freedoms” (Kotek), what is actually being said? My points about the unrestrained operation of ICE in Oregon cities and on Oregon university campuses are wholly unaddressed, and no truth has been gained, no knowledge ascertained, and even though I wouldn’t say that I have been lied to, it feels as though the rhetoric used towards me here was fundamentally empty and symbolic, and served no genuine purpose. By Booth’s standards, perhaps we can consider this response an unethical use of Win Rhetoric – C, where Kotek’s ultimate aim is to remain in good standing as a politician, and is thus willing to dispense empty, high-minded rhetoric to encourage a complacent and unheard constituency, but again, I struggle to label the response as inherently deceptive. By considering this interaction through the lens of rhetorical agency, understanding the ethicality may be clarified, there are factors of time and bandwidth at play, Kotek simply would not have the time to open a personal dialogue with every citizen of Oregon, and thus some generalized responses

must be made. I also have to understand my role as a citizen in a democracy, in which Kotek is meant to represent in interests of my state in a utilitarian sense, and my voice isn't the most meaningful (especially considering I am not a political action committee with millions of dollars to spend). We also have to consider that our state government is at odds with the structurally more powerful federal government, and my rhetoric is ultimately being used against a middleman who may not have the power to change, even with a shared understanding of truth.

Ultimately, there are far too many factors at play to fit into any one framework. While Booth's framework is highly applicable, Hoff-Clausen's plea to consider the vastness of the environment we use rhetoric in highlights the shortcomings of more theoretical frameworks. We have to "strive to neither locate rhetorical agency exclusively in individuals, nor practically dissolve it in the governance of structures over more or less will-less subjects" (Hoff-Clausen, 12) and find ways in which we can utilize our rhetoric despite how disempowered it may become because of larger structural systems and restraints. While I have essentially no agency in trying to contact my governor, and my governor's team clearly has no interest in interacting with my rhetoric, I think that there is still an ethical attempt being made at ethical discourse, though the limitations of larger structures are clearly overwhelming.

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Unrevised Unit Paper #2

Persecution Complexes on College Campuses

In her article *I Came to College Eager to Debate. I Found Self-Censorship Instead*, Emma Camp calls attention to the lack of free and open discourse on college campuses. However, the examples she chooses fall back into a pattern of dominant ideologies of thought crying ‘persecution’ to speech or policy aimed at including nondominant ideologies. Camp’s points about how college campus discussions often become “monotonous echo chambers... mired in socially safe ideas” are fundamentally sound and draw attention to a significant threat to modern discourse and ethics. Camp’s examples, however intentional, use rhetoric from members of groups like [Republicans](#), [white people](#), and [Christians](#), who statistically represent dominant groups in America. These groups, whose ideologies are represented overwhelmingly by our government and culture, often react negatively to any opposing viewpoint being given attention or merit, often perceiving this lack of control as a punishment due to their beliefs.

One example of this happening in Camp’s article is a section where she discusses a college professor, Samuel Abrams, whose office door was vandalized, and a protest was organized against him (unsuccessfully) (Camp). This example, as Camp presented it, seemed like an outrageous reaction from students aiming to silence his critique of a “lack of ideological diversity among university administrators” (Camp) which is in itself, again, a real threat to ethical discourse. Where the logic begins to dissipate however, is when we actually follow the link to the article, titled “Think Professors Are Liberal? Try School Administrators” (Abrams). If this wasn’t enough of a clue that Abrams may not be the champion of ideological diversity he claims to be, Abrams goes on to explain how he was “taken aback” by his schools sponsorship of

“lopsided” topics such as Black Lives Matter, events promoting justice for: women, and lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer, intersex, asexual, and allied people, as well as events covering topics like microaggressions and white privilege (Abrams). Where the rhetoric starts to become misleading is when Abrams describes the issue as there not being enough of a “meaningful ideological alternative” (Abrams). But what is the ideological alternative to justice for people in marginalized groups? What is the alternative to the existence of white privilege or microaggressions? What is the alternative to Black Lives Matter? Abrams coincidentally does not elaborate on this. What Abrams, and in turn Camp, fail to address with these arguments, is that the ideologies that are supposedly dominating educational spaces are simply ones that lie outside of the larger ideological norm in America. The answer to all of my rhetorical questions about Abrams piece really is: the status quo in the United States.

By including examples that hinge upon white, conservative students and professors feeling they cannot express their views openly, Camp is evoking the idea of a silent majority. An idea that is truly a misrepresentation of modern rhetorical discourse, allowing members of a dominant, and often discriminatory ideology to claim victimhood, and label any pushback to their ideas as punishment. Not only does this move rhetorically sympathize with an oppressive, dominant ideology, but it also raises ethical concerns about what self-censorship and punishment actually are. Camp uses language like “we keep our voices low”, “I sometimes feel afraid to full speak my mind”, “somewhat uncomfortable”, to describe the impact of the cultural force that engenders self-censorship (Camp). This force, however, never seems to progress beyond the point of discomfort, leaving the punishment for not self-censoring as an uncomfortable social ostracization. The connection that Camp does not make in her article, is that the dominant progressive voices on college campuses often represent groups that have historically and actually

(legally or otherwise) been punished. Referring back to the list of events that Abrams was concerned about, all of them represented groups that have been discriminated against overtly and with genuine force by a government of a white, male, republican, Christian nation. Camp then draws the conclusion from this cultural atmosphere that the lack of ideological discourse is an intentional exclusion of viewpoints, rather than what I believe it more accurately is: an accumulation of marginalized voices.

Taking into consideration how lopsided the dominant culture of America is, from elected political officials to the pervading force of white supremacy, it seems like an ethically questionable move from Camp to emphasize the stories of people who side with the majority who face self-censorship. The shift on college campuses towards more progressive ideologies is one that prioritizes discourse and diversity inherently, as it allows for thought that is rejected by, and genuinely persecuted by the dominant culture. When Camp focuses on the dominant reaction to those spaces, she is missing the larger context of American society. Even to that end, there are still many ideological movements outside the dominant culture that are genuinely persecuted by students and administration alike. Student protests for labor rights or Palestinian liberation have been systematically silenced by ‘overwhelmingly liberal’ administrations. God forbid any student in an economics class considers anything outside the bounds of capitalism. Not to mention the overwhelmingly white demographics of so many colleges. To focus on the relatively low stakes of losing friends and facing pushback from students (Camp) instead of considering the genuine censorship and ideological conformity to the American status quo, Camp uses a rhetorically sound argument, but backs it with some unfortunately unethical examples.

I’m still unsure where I stand on the function of Camp’s article. While the premise of her argument is one I can theoretically support, her application of the argument reinforces some very

concerning right-wing political dogma. The sources she cites, and anecdotes she includes all orbit members of majority groups of our nation's political theater, who see the presence of voices that conflict with their own as a force that persecutes, punishes, and forces them into a state of silence, when this is one of the farthest things from reality. All discourse that takes place within America inherently has the cultural status quo as context, it always interacts with, moves within, and is in discourse with the dominant ideology. When marginalized groups have to act, politically or socially, to make their voices heard in discourse, it takes power away from that dominant group. However, these groups in no way silence, persecute, or punish the dominant voice of white, Christian, conservative Americans, they simply are seeking spaces to have their voices heard.

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Additional Inspiration

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YIw98lnIBHA&t=203s&ab_channel=BeliefItOrNot

Revised Unit Paper

Ethical Implications of Rhetorical Agency

Rhetoric, while a powerful tool for communication and the creation of change, is inevitably constrained by the realities of power, access, and audience. The agency available to a rhetor—or their capacity to enact change through language (Hoff-Clausen, 294)—is shaped by structural, societal, economic, and situational limitations. Evaluating rhetorical agency can be done by analyzing the larger dynamics at play behind when, how, and to what degree of efficacy rhetoric can be used. It is easiest to see these constraints in top-down interactions of rhetoric and there are unfavorable ethical implications in their inequality. By applying a framework of rhetorical agency based on the definition and application offered by Hoff-Clausen, I plan to approach the different kinds of rhetoric used between social structures and individuals based on Booth’s “Judging Rhetoric”. While the constructions of rhetoric within discourse communities, and the idea of discourse between interlocutors are useful, I want to try to focus on the agency that different actors have when using rhetoric, and how these interactions can be inherently unethical. The premise of my analysis is the agency associated with different rhetorical actors. The example I will use to explore this will be me attempting to contact Governor Tina Kotek.

Rhetorical agency broadly defined, refers to the capacity to act, or enact change through language. Hoff-Clausen’s definition of rhetorical agency is a response to the question: “What are the sources of [the] capacity to act through language?” (Abstract). Hoff-Clausen frames rhetorical agency as something not attributed solely to the individual or the system, but rather an interplay between their subjectivity and the structural

conditions they are speaking under. Hoff-Clausen's definition of rhetorical agency can be briefly summarized with the idea that:

Within the dialectical lines of thinking, scholars might speak of agents, choice, intentions, and of a will which directs our activities, but they recognize that our subjectivities are of our social reality, and hence of symbolic and material conditions—conditions, that is, whose determinations we may, however, reflect upon, object to, and try to alter. So the scholar working from this understanding of agency strives neither to locate rhetorical agency exclusively in individuals, nor to practically dissolve it in the governance of structures over subjects more or less lacking in will (Hoff-Clausen 291).

As with so many other rhetorical modes of analysis, an understanding of rhetorical agency is intersectional, ever-changing and fluid. Each case of rhetorical interpretation can access unique corners of our understanding. There is an incommensurable quality between our static understanding of agency and our applied understanding of agency, they must be applied in order to be fully understood. My functional definition of rhetoric is to see it as a method of constructing a shared reality. A tool that uses communication and dialogue in search of mutual understanding, compromise, or influence. But this operative function of rhetoric does not exist in a vacuum, it is often unattainable when rhetors use it under unequal conditions. Institutions, governments, and corporations systematically possess more rhetorical agency than individuals. An individual rarely has the opportunity, platform, the reach, or the authority to be a more influential voice than the well-organized powers that be. This is not only because of their access to resources, but they often control platforms of discourse, can set cultural expectations of communication, and have

naturalized their authority as rhetorical agents through structural power (Hoff-Clausen, 294). The imbalance in dialogue that arises from these systematic advantages raises ethical concerns about whose **voice is heard, respected, and naturalized into a shared reality. This also poses the question of who remains unheard?**

To explore this question, I attempted to engage in rhetorical discourse with Governor Tina Kotek. I sent an email questioning why federal immigration agencies are permitted to operate freely within Oregon, which is a self-declared sanctuary state. When rhetorical interactions happen between individuals, societies, and systems, there are different levels of agency available to the actor, especially contingent on the willingness of the second party to listen or interact. **This interaction** will be **analyzed** through the construction of rhetorical agency that Hoff-Clausen offers, and it will **be informed by** Booth's ideas about rhetorical methods and types. **The imposed inequality between me and Tina Kotek shows a difference in rhetorical agency, through which it can be argued that rhetors with more structural power** can impose their construction of truth on the smaller groups more easily than in reverse. I also want to address the restraints in agency that rhetors have in when using rhetoric, and how systems of power often lead to individuals and minority groups having a lack of agency, thus disempowering their rhetoric, and placing them in an inherently unethical imbalance of dialogue.

The response I received was not from Tina Kotek, but rather "Governor Kotek's Constituent Services Team" (Kotek), and rather than genuinely addressing my question, I received a message comprised entirely of boilerplate rhetoric and buzzwords, which never addressed my message. **The message is full of empty gestures and rhetoric that feels empty like,** "Governor Kotek remains focused on making progress on Oregonian's top priorities and

will fight to protect Oregon values no matter what's happening in D.C.” (Kotek). **While the message does serve as a gesture towards shared values and ethics, it fails to address my question in any direct way, or even acknowledge the details of my message.** Under Booth's framework, when I send an email to the office of Tina Kotek, I am utilizing listening rhetoric – b: *“Though I am quite sure that my opponent is determined to ignore my case, I will listen to [theirs], hoping to discover some way to engage [them] in genuine dialogue”* (47). While Booth describes this interaction as one that poses the rhetor against “dogmatists who seem to be unshakably committed to an absolutely unquestionable cause” (47), this situation seems more complex. **It is clear that from Booth's perspective, Tina Kotek is lacking the ethical integrity of the genuine listener, and is unwilling to engage with my points directly. I approached the situation with intent to open discourse, hoping that a respectful, reasonable inquiry might prompt a genuine exchange of ideas. However, Booth's ideas don't fully capture the rhetorical interaction taking place here, as it feels difficult to describe Tina Kotek as an unshakable dogmatist. Rather, there are other factors at play in this scenario, and while Booth's points don't accurately capture what this interaction is, Hoff-Clausen has a more practical explanation.**

Hoff-Clausen posits that there is a dimension beyond willingness that allows dialogue to occur, and that we should look to “the many contextual factors of influence... to how the speakers and their audiences are positioned [in] ... situational, organization, and societal structures” (Hoff-Clausen, 296). This idea of limitation goes both ways, when Hoff-Clausen says that “agency precedes the agent” (292), here it means that before I ever sent my message, I knew it wouldn't be genuinely considered by my government (which Booth's framework does align with). **This idea also means that there are factors that may prevent Tina Kotek from**

opening a genuine dialogue with me as well. When considering the response I received, however, there are a few questions raised. Which of Booth's frameworks does this fit into? I can't find a satisfying answer, as the response is automated, and sought in no way to interact with my rhetoric, the only goal seeming to be a half-assed seeking of complacency. When Kotek's team says she will "work to ensure our laws, policies and actions remain a deterrent to attacks on our shared values and fundamental freedoms" (Kotek), what is actually being said? My points about the unrestrained operation of ICE in Oregon cities and on Oregon university campuses are wholly unaddressed, and no truth has been gained, no knowledge ascertained, and even though I wouldn't say that I have been lied to, it feels as though the rhetoric used towards me here was fundamentally empty and symbolic, and served no genuine purpose. By Booth's standards, perhaps we can consider this response an unethical use of Win Rhetoric – C, where Kotek's ultimate aim is to remain in good standing as a politician, and is thus willing to dispense empty, high-minded rhetoric to encourage a complacent and unheard constituency, but again, I struggle to label the response as inherently deceptive.

By considering this interaction through the lens of rhetorical agency, understanding the ethicality becomes easier, there are factors of time and bandwidth at play, Kotek simply would not have the time to open a personal dialogue with every citizen of Oregon, and thus some generalized responses must be made. I also have to understand my role as a citizen in a democracy, in which Kotek is meant to represent in interests of my state in a utilitarian sense, and my voice isn't the most meaningful (especially considering I am not a political action committee with millions of dollars to spend). We also have to consider that our state government is at odds with the structurally more powerful federal government, and my rhetoric is ultimately

being used against a middleman who may not have the power to change, even with a shared understanding of truth.

All of this is to point to the ethical imbalance at the center of this interaction: when rhetorical agency is distributed unequally, and when those with institutional power systematically avoid engagement, the result is rhetorical disenfranchisement. My voice, though seeking genuine discourse, was effectively silenced. Tina Kotek, while not genuinely attempting to silence is, is limited by time, but also by the optics of speaking out on pressing issues. So while I can't entirely blame Kotek for my lack of rhetorical agency, the structure of communication with a government institution—and the reliance on generic, depersonalized rhetoric that comes with it—functioned in a way that denied me agency as both a constituent, and a person.

The question of rhetorical agency is one that is being discussed across all modes of communication, including digital spaces. A work that grapples with the challenges of understanding rhetorical agency online is Goodling's *MOAR Digital Activism, Please*. The questions that Goodling poses in the first post of the article are exploring understanding the purpose of digital activism. By purpose, I mean to say, the efficacy, the agency behind digital activism. In Goodling's own words, "if we are using change as a metric, can't nearly any form of activism be labeled a success-or failure—depending on who is assessing?... I would argue that acquisition of new information... is a change in degree of engagement" (1). It returns to Hoff-Clausen's questions of what we can do with language. Goodling and Hoff-Clausen are essentially using the same metric of enacting change (literal or otherwise) through language. Goodling, however, closes in on the corner of digital activism in order to dissect the ethical implications of a new and complex form of rhetorical application.

Goodling argues that public forums in digital spaces provide individuals with far more rhetorical agency than larger institutional systems. They argue that the ability to mobilize, spread information rapidly, and have an unrestricted reach of voice is an incredibly powerful access to public discourse for many politically active people. In this case, I myself as an individual would have access to public forums and could try to organize a political movement myself against the issues that Tina Kotek ignores in my email.

Ultimately, there are far too many factors at play to fit into any one framework. While Booth's framework is highly applicable, Hoff-Clausen's plea to consider the vastness of the environment we use rhetoric in highlights the shortcomings of more theoretical frameworks. We have to "strive to neither locate rhetorical agency exclusively in individuals, nor practically dissolve it in the governance of structures over more or less will-less subjects" (Hoff-Clausen, 12) and find ways in which we can utilize our rhetoric despite how disempowered it may become because of larger structural systems and restraints. While I have essentially no agency in trying to contact my governor, and my governor's team clearly has no interest in interacting with my rhetoric, I think that there is still an ethical attempt being made at ethical discourse, though the limitations of larger structures are clearly overwhelming. **This all leads to the larger ethical imperative: to recognize, critique, and understand the systems that disenfranchise rhetorical discourse. Hoff-Clausen's framework is good for understanding that rhetorical agency is both inside and outside of our control. Booth's work seeks an ethical exchange between rhetors, and in turn allows us to recognize unethical exchanges taking place. And Goodling's work gives us options and tools to attain rhetorical agency in a society structured to take it away from us. No one single framework is sufficient to understand the**

issue, but together they offer the tools to pragmatically work our way through our continued lack of rhetorical agency as members of American society at large.

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